

matters Francis Story knew much more about the peoples of South Asia than they knew themselves. This was not said as a shallow repetition of the cliché according to which we never see ourselves as others see us. Francis Story had a lively interest in all sorts of subtle differences of custom which made him an unrivalled expert on the peoples among whom he lived. I sometimes wondered why, during all the years he lived in Asia, he had never learned a modern Asian language; but perhaps if he had done so the time and effort would have left him with less to devote to the study of other aspects of the cultures of the region.

He was not, however, satisfied with the mere collection of data. He wanted to learn—and even to anticipate—the patterns which began to emerge from the cases. He constantly thought and talked about their similarities and differences and their relationship to the Dhamma. It is altogether appropriate therefore that about half of the present volume consists of writings on what we might call the theoretical aspects of rebirth. But the essays of Francis Story on the theory of rebirth, in my opinion, stand far above those of most theorists of the subject. For although most of them have never been near a case, Francis Story from personal experience could see the relevance of Buddhist texts to cases and of cases to texts. His report and subsequent comments about the case of the Karen houseboy with appalling deformities (reprinted in Chapter XXII of this volume) provide only one example of his unusual powers of integration.

He was particularly interested in “international cases,” those in which a subject claims to have lived a previous life in another country. The case of Ranjith Makalanda (reported in Chapter XXI of this volume) provides an excellent example of the type. The subject, a Sinhalese boy of Sri Lanka, claimed that he had been an Englishman in his previous life and he had certain English habits that harmonized with his (unfortunately unverified) statements about the previous life he claimed to remember. Francis Story liked to muse over how such an event as a Christian Englishman being reborn a Sinhalese Buddhist could happen. Occasionally he talked about his own particular fondness for Chinese and Indo-Chinese peoples and a few odd likings and other traits he had which made him speculate that he himself might have had a previous life as a Chinese.

The reasons why a person might be reborn in one particular family (of the same culture) rather than in another also fascinated him. The fact that the subject's birth often occurred near the place of death—verified or conjectured—of the previous personality drew his attention. Some of us finally developed “Story's Law” which says: “Other things being equal, a